Indians, of course, must be conscious that the world has a lot riding on our decisions. Those who wish us well will endeavour to cooperate. Others who see our rise less favourably will obstruct, if not do worse. Either way, we must be prepared for those who will participate in our discourse, even intervene in pursuit of their interests. As discussed earlier, it is vital that we do not open ourselves to the external shaping of our prospects. India certainly matters to its own people, and for that very reason, we must recall from history why our future must not be decided by those outside.

The place that India has long occupied in global thinking is manifest in the obsessive search for trade routes to it. They may have initially taken European explorers to the American continent. But when the explorers finally reached India by sea, even more significant consequences unfolded. Using it as an effective base, Europe was able to thereafter dominate the rest of Asia. In fact, even China's fate in the nineteenth century was very much shaped by the outcomes in India.

Not surprisingly, this centrality of India worked the other way around as well. Its independence set in motion a larger decolonization process that became the basis for the contemporary global order. Decades later, India's economic progress contributes to a rebalancing and multipolarity that is still unfolding. These may be some illustrations of an argument on why India matters. Pondering over its past importance certainly helps to gauge its future relevance.

Part of why India counts is obvious. For a start, it represents a sixth of humanity. So, its successes and shortcomings have clear global connotations. But for Partition, India, and not China, would have been the largest society in living memory. The case for India is, however, more than just one of demography. For it is among the few civilizational states that has survived the ravages of history. Such polities are distinguished by a different level of culture and heritage, with accompanying attitudes and mindset as well. They take the long view, especially in regard to global issues. Many of their goals and objectives also build on traditions that are not readily shared by contemporary peers. Simply put, there is not only a scale and history but an exceptionalism about India that makes it matter.

Societies can be relevant as a playing field for others or they can be players by themselves. The colonial era with its ruthless extractive culture presented that sharp choice in the last few centuries. You were either a victim or an assailant; there was no middle ground. However, the progress